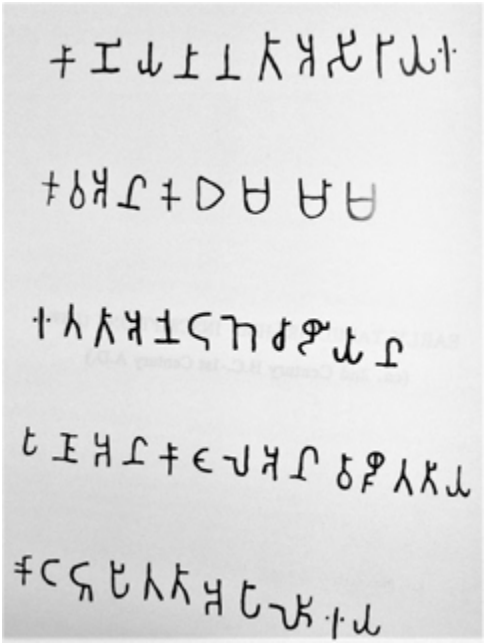


The Tamil epigraphist Iravatham Mahadevan chalking in a Tamil-Brahmi inscription on the walls of a cave at Alagarmalai in 1992.



The longest inscription from the Mankulam caves, shown by Mahadevan to be the earliest Tamil-Brahmi inscription yet found. It reads: ‘Charity to Nanta-siri Kuvan, the kani [senior Jain monk]. Behold! The hermitage was caused to be carved by Katalan Valuti, the servant of Netuncaliyan.’